PUPIL NAME: _____ CLASS: _____ TEACHER: _____

ORIGINS OF THE FIRST WORLD WAR • 1871–1914

Causes of the Great War (1871–1914)

From Bismarckian Unification & Imperial Rivalry to the Guns of August 1914

5 ENQUIRIES
16-PAGE STANDARD



PRIMARY PHOTOGRAPH • PORTSMOUTH (c. 1906–1907)

PRIMARY EVIDENCE • NAVAL REVOLUTION

HMS Dreadnought at Sea (1906)

Royal Navy Photographic Archives

Launched in February 1906 by the British Admiralty, HMS Dreadnought carried ten 12-inch guns and turbine engines, rendering all existing battleships instantly obsolete and resetting the global naval race to zero.

SIGNIFICANCE: The naval arms race transformed Anglo-German trading partners into suspicious military rivals, driving Britain into the Triple Entente with France and Russia.

HINGE QUESTION:
Did the launch of HMS Dreadnought protect British imperial security, or did it dangerously erase Britain's established naval advantage?

Vessel Type: Royal Navy All-Big-Gun Battleship • Steam Turbine Propulsion • 17,900 Tons

PORTSMOUTH DOCKYARD • PENNANT 01

1. CHRONOLOGICAL SPINES [ENQUIRIES 1–5]
Structured chronological note-taking on each left page: 5 causal stages guiding pupil understanding as the teacher narrates the history.

2. WRITING PRACTICE [4M, 8M, 12M]
Targeted extended writing on each right page: causal explanation essays, feature drills, narrative accounts, and contrasting interpretations.

3. CENTREFOLD LIVING TIMELINE & NOTES
Centrefold Living Timeline dual-coding sketchpads (pp. 8–9) and dedicated lined notes & essay planning spreads (pp. 14–15).

COURSE SPECIFICATION • KEY ENQUIRY SEQUENCE	LEARNT	REVISED
Enquiry 1: German Unification, Franco-Prussian War & Bismarck (1871–1890) *How did the creation of the German Empire and the seizure of Alsace-Lorraine permanently rupture European peace?*	☐	☐
Enquiry 2: Imperial Rivalry, the Scramble for Africa & the Moroccan Crises (1884–1911) *How did imperial ambition in Africa and Kaiser Wilhelm II's "Weltpolitik" bring European powers to the brink of war?*	☐	☐
Enquiry 3: The Anglo-German Naval Arms Race & HMS Dreadnought (1898–1914) *Why did a battleship building contest destroy Anglo-German relations and reset naval supremacy?*	☐	☐
Enquiry 4: The Alliance Systems & the Balkan Powder Keg (1879–1913) *Did European military alliances protect continental peace or guarantee a domino-effect catastrophe?*	☐	☐
Enquiry 5: The July Crisis: Sarajevo to the Outbreak of War (June–August 1914) *Why did a single assassination in Sarajevo ignite thirty-seven days of diplomatic madness and world war?*	☐	☐

In 1871, the German Empire had a population of 41 million; by 1914, it had surged to 68 million industrial powerhouses.

How did the creation of the German Empire and the seizure of Alsace-Lorraine permanently rupture European peace?

Core Specification Focus: 1815 Congress of Vienna balance of power; Prussian military reforms & Krupp industrial steel; Otto von Bismarck's Realpolitik and "Iron & Blood" statecraft; Franco-Prussian War (1870–71) & proclamation at Versailles; Treaty of Frankfurt, 5 billion franc indemnity & annexation of Alsace-Lorraine; French national "Revanche"; Bismarckian diplomacy to isolate France and avoid a two-front war.

CHRONOLOGICAL INQUIRY SPINE • CORE CAUSAL NARRATIVE *Construct your causal explanation for each stage incorporating the core trigger terms*

Stage 1 Text [1.1] 1862–1866 • What enabled Prussia to overturn the 1815 balance of power?

- 39 Fragmented States
- Bismarck's Blood & Iron Speech
- Krupp Heavy Rail Artillery

Stage 2 Text [1.2] 1870–1871 • How was the German Empire proclaimed at Versailles in 1871?

- Hall of Mirrors Ceremony
- Napoleon III Sedan Surrender
- Hohenzollern Imperial Ascendancy

Stage 3 Text [1.3] May 1871 • Why did the annexation of Alsace-Lorraine shatter peace?

- Treaty of Frankfurt Clauses
- 5 Billion Gold Franc Indemnity
- Permanent Continental Rupture

Stage 4 Text [1.4] 1871–1889 • In what ways did French "Revanche" shape patriotic culture?

- Classroom Maps Veiled in Black
- Sacred National Retribution
- Universal Peacetime Conscription

Stage 5 Text [1.5] 1871–1890 • Evaluate how Bismarck's diplomacy isolated the French Republic.

- 1887 Reinsurance Treaty
- Nightmare of Encirclement
- Quarantine of Paris

In 1871, Bismarck crowned Wilhelm I inside the Hall of Mirrors at Versailles, deliberately inflicting a deep wound on French national pride.

Question 2: Explain Why [12 marks • 15 mins]

EXTENDED WRITING PRACTICE

Explain why the creation of the German Empire in 1871 created long-term instability in Europe. [12 marks]

Stimulus: **The annexation of Alsace-Lorraine** | **Bismarck's dread of a two-front war** *(You must also use information of your own)*

ANALYTICAL CONNECTIVES:

A decisive factor was... • This led directly to... • Furthermore... • In consequence of this... • Ultimately, this meant that...

KEY VOCABULARY BANK:

Otto von Bismarck • Realpolitik • Blood and Iron • Hall of Mirrors • Treaty of Frankfurt • Alsace-Lorraine • Revanche • Balance of Power • Two-Front War

Task: *Using the vocabulary and connectives above, write your analytical response below:*

LIVING TIMELINE MISSION

Turn to Centrefold • Pages 8–9 →

Turn to Centrefold (Pages 8–9). Complete Milestone 1 (1871 Proclamation of the German Empire at Versailles) using dual-coding symbols and key dates.

How did imperial ambition in Africa and Kaiser Wilhelm II's "Weltpolitik" bring European powers to the brink of war?

Core Specification Focus: Scramble for Africa (1881–1914); Berlin West Africa Conference (1884–85) and rules of effective occupation; Kaiser Wilhelm II dismisses Bismarck (1890) and demands Germany's "place in the sun"; Weltpolitik ("World Policy"); First Moroccan Crisis & Kaiser's landing at Tangier (1905); Algeciras Conference (1906); Second Moroccan Crisis & gunboat Panther at Agadir (1911); Mansion House speech; consolidation of the Anglo-French Entente Cordiale.

CHRONOLOGICAL INQUIRY SPINE • CORE CAUSAL NARRATIVE *Construct your causal explanation for each stage incorporating the core trigger terms*

Stage 1 [Text 2.1] 1884–1885 • Why did European empires carve up Africa in the 1880s Scramble?

- Effective Occupation Principle
- Rubber, Copper & Mineral Wealth
- Imperial Partition Across Continents

Stage 2 [Text 2.2] 1890–1897 • Explain why Wilhelm II launched "Weltpolitik" in the 1890s.

- Chancellorship Dismissal (1890)
- Demand for "Place in the Sun"
- Aggressive Overseas Expansion

Stage 3 [Text 2.3] March 1905 • What happened when the Kaiser landed at Tangier in 1905?

- White Horse Imperial Parade
- Testing Anglo-French Entente
- Sultanate Sovereignty Asserted

Stage 4 [Text 2.4] 1906 • To what extent did the 1906 Algeciras Conference isolate Germany?

- Ten-to-Two Diplomatic Defeat
- Whitehall Naval Solidarity
- Hostile Encirclement Paranoia

Stage 5 [Text 2.5] July 1911 • Why did the gunboat Panther at Agadir bring Europe close to war?

- Naval Intimidation Tactics
- Mansion House Public Warning
- Joint Staff Military Planning

The Berlin Conference of 1884–85 carved up the African continent with rulers and pencils, completely ignoring indigenous cultures and borders.

Question 1: Describe Two Features [4 marks • 5 mins]

FEATURE DRILL

Describe two features of the 1911 Agadir Crisis (Second Moroccan Crisis). [4 marks]

Question 2: Explain One Consequence [4 marks • 5 mins]

STRUCTURED WRITING

Explain one consequence of the Moroccan Crises for relations between Great Britain and France. [4 marks]

Stimulus: The 1906 Algeciras Conference | The 1911 Mansion House Speech

Analytical Connectives: *A decisive consequence was... • This happened because... • As a direct result... • Consequently, this led to... • Ultimately, this meant that...*

Key Terms: Kaiser Wilhelm II • Weltpolitik • Tangier (1905) • Algeciras Conference • Panther at Agadir (1911) • David Lloyd George • Mansion House Speech • Entente Cordiale

LIVING TIMELINE MISSION

Turn to Centrefold • Pages 8–9 →

Turn to Centrefold (Pages 8–9). Complete Milestone 3 (The Berlin Conference) and Milestone 7 (The Panther at Agadir) using dual-coding sketches and dates.

Why did a battleship building contest destroy Anglo-German relations and reset naval supremacy?

Core Specification Focus: Britain's island dependence on maritime trade; the Two-Power Standard; Admiral Alfred von Tirpitz and the German Naval Laws (1898, 1900); Tirpitz's "Risk Theory"; Admiral Sir John Fisher and naval revolution; launch of HMS Dreadnought (1906); 1909 British naval panic ("We want eight and we won't wait!"); economic costs and super-dreadnoughts; failure of the 1912 Haldane Mission.

CHRONOLOGICAL INQUIRY SPINE • CORE CAUSAL NARRATIVE *Construct your causal explanation for each stage incorporating the core trigger terms*

Stage 1 Text [3.1] 1889–1897 • Why was naval supremacy vital for Great Britain's survival?

• 1889 Naval Defence Act	
• Vulnerable Maritime Food Convoys	
• Two-Power Fleet Dominance	

Stage 2 Text [3.2] 1898–1900 • How did Tirpitz's "Risk Theory" plan to challenge the Royal Navy?

• 1898 & 1900 Fleet Acts	
• High Seas North Sea Concentration	
• Deterrence via Existential Threat	

Stage 3 Text [3.3] February 1906 • Why did HMS Dreadnought reset naval supremacy to zero?

• Ten 12-Inch Heavy Guns	
• Steam Turbine Speed Advantage	
• Pre-Dreadnoughts Instantly Obsolete	

Stage 4 Text [3.4] 1909 • What triggered the 1909 British naval panic ("We want eight")?

• Secret Krupp Slipway Expansion	
• Sensationalist Press Alarmism	
• Doubled Battleship Construction	

Stage 5 Text [3.5] 1912–1914 • Evaluate why the 1912 Haldane Mission failed to stop the arms race.

• Berlin Diplomatic Mission	
• Unconditional Neutrality Demand	
• Mediterranean-North Sea Accord	

HMS Dreadnought possessed ten 12-inch guns and turbine engines, rendering every battleship on earth instantly obsolete on 10 February 1906.

Question 3: Historiographical Analysis [8 marks • 10 mins]

HISTORIOGRAPHICAL ANALYSIS

INTERPRETATION 1 • PROFESSOR PAUL KENNEDY • THE RISE OF ANGLO-GERMAN ANTAGONISM

"The naval race was the single most dangerous element in pre-1914 European diplomacy. For Britain, naval supremacy was not a luxury; it was the foundation of national survival and empire. When Germany began massing battleships directly across the North Sea, it transformed what had been friendly commercial relations into bitter existential suspicion. British leaders concluded that a German battlefleet could only be designed for one purpose: to destroy British naval power and dominate Europe."

INTERPRETATION 2 • PROFESSOR CHRISTOPHER CLARK • THE SLEEPWALKERS

"Historians have greatly exaggerated the fatal impact of the naval race. By 1912, the battleship race was effectively over: Germany had abandoned the contest to concentrate resources on its land army, while Britain retained an insurmountable dreadnought lead. What ultimately triggered the catastrophe was not steel battleships in the North Sea, but unstable ethnic nationalism, crumbling imperial frontiers, and fatal alliance commitments in the volatile Balkan peninsula."

Study Interpretations 1 and 2. How do they differ about the causes of the Anglo-German naval arms race? [4 marks] PART B

Suggest one reason why Interpretations 1 and 2 differ about the causes of the naval arms race. [4 marks] PART C

LIVING TIMELINE MISSION

Turn to Centrefold • Pages 8–9 →

Turn to Centrefold (Pages 8–9). Complete Milestone 6 (1906 Launch of HMS Dreadnought) using dual-coding symbols, gun turrets, and turbine funnels.

LIVING TIMELINE • PART 1: UNIFICATION, IMPERIALISM & DREADNOUGHTS (1871–1906)

Living Timeline Dual-Coding Protocol: Complete each milestone sketchpad using dual-coding (combining visual storytelling symbols, causal arrows, and dates) to master the chronological spine across the centre-fold.

1871 • Proclamation of the German Empire at Versailles

Enquiry 1

Inside the Hall of Mirrors at Versailles, Prussian King Wilhelm I is crowned German Emperor. Bismarck unites 39 states into a dominant military giant, permanently shattering the 1815 balance of power.

1871 • Treaty of Frankfurt & Seizure of Alsace-Lorraine

Enquiry 1

France signs the Treaty of Frankfurt, ceding mineral-rich Alsace-Lorraine and paying a 5 billion franc indemnity. French national "Revanche" is born, permanently poisoning Franco-German relations.

1884–1885 • The Berlin Conference & The Scramble for Africa

Enquiry 2

Bismarck hosts European empires in Berlin to carve up Africa under rules of "effective occupation", triggering a furious race for colonial territories, raw materials, and imperial prestige.

1890 • Kaiser Wilhelm II Dismisses Bismarck & Abandons Russia

Enquiry 2/4

Wilhelm II dismisses Chancellor Bismarck ("Dropping the Pilot") and allows the Reinsurance Treaty with Russia to lapse, opening the door for the 1894 Franco-Russian Alliance and encirclement.

Centrefold timeline: Dual-coding sketches and dates turns narrative history into permanent long-term memory.

LIVING TIMELINE • PART 2: CRISES, ALLIANCES & OUTBREAK OF WAR (1905–1914)

Living Timeline Dual-Coding Protocol: Complete each milestone sketchpad using dual-coding (combining visual storytelling symbols, causal arrows, and dates) to master the chronological spine across the centre-fold.

1905 • The First Moroccan Crisis & Tangier Landing

Enquiry 2

Kaiser Wilhelm II lands at Tangier to disrupt French control of Morocco and test the Entente Cordiale; the 1906 Algeciras Conference humiliates Germany, leaving Berlin bitter and isolated.

1906 • Launch of HMS Dreadnought & Naval Arms Race

Enquiry 3

The Royal Navy launches HMS Dreadnought, making all previous battleships instantly obsolete. Admiral Tirpitz accelerates German naval laws, sparking an intense battleship building contest in the North Sea.

1911 • The Panther at Agadir (Second Moroccan Crisis)

Enquiry 2

Germany sends the gunboat Panther to Agadir, prompting David Lloyd George's Mansion House warning. Britain and France initiate secret joint military and naval conversations, cementing their alliance.

28 June 1914 • The Sarajevo Assassination & Outbreak of War

Enquiry 5

Gavrilo Princip assassinates Archduke Franz Ferdinand in Sarajevo. Germany grants Austria-Hungary the "Blank Cheque", setting off a chain reaction of mobilizations that plunges Europe into world war.

Did European military alliances protect continental peace or guarantee a domino-effect catastrophe?

Core Specification Focus: The Dual Alliance (1879) and Triple Alliance (1882); Franco-Russian Military Alliance (1894); Entente Cordiale (1904) and Anglo-Russian Convention (1907) creating the Triple Entente; decay of the Ottoman Empire; Pan-Slavic nationalism; Austrian annexation of Bosnia-Herzegovina (1908); Russian diplomatic humiliation; Balkan Wars (1912–13); Serbia as a grave threat to the Austro-Hungarian Empire.

CHRONOLOGICAL INQUIRY SPINE • CORE CAUSAL NARRATIVE *Construct your causal explanation for each stage incorporating the core trigger terms*

Stage 1 [Text [4.1]] 1879–1882 • How did Bismarck's Dual Alliance create a Central European bloc?

• Habsburg Mutual Defence Treaty	
• Triple Coalition Expansion	
• Anti-Russian Security Shield	

Stage 2 [Text [4.2]] 1894–1907 • Explain why the 1894 Franco-Russian Alliance broke isolation.

• St Petersburg Capital Loans	
• 1904 Entente Cordiale Accord	
• Counterbalancing Triple Entente	

Stage 3 [Text [4.3]] 1900–1908 • Why was south-eastern Europe known as the "Balkan Powder Keg"?

• Collapsing Ottoman Authority	
• Pan-Slavic Liberation Ambitions	
• Austro-Russian Imperial Clash	

Stage 4 [Text [4.4]] October 1908 • What were the consequences of the 1908 Bosnian Annexation Crisis?

• Habsburg Territory Seizure	
• Belgrade Public Indignation	
• Humiliated Tsarist Capitulation	

Stage 5 [Text [4.5]] 1912–1913 • To what extent did the 1912–13 Balkan Wars embolden Serbia?

• Regional League Military Campaigns	
• Doubled Territory & Manpower	
• Vienna Pre-emptive Strike Urge	

The European alliance system was designed to deter war through mutual balance; instead, it acted like a string of linked dynamite.

Question 1: Narrative Account [8 marks • 10 mins]

PART A • NARRATIVE

Write a narrative account analysing how crises in the Balkans between 1908 and 1913 increased European tension. [8 marks]

Stimulus: The Bosnian Annexation Crisis (1908) | The Balkan Wars (1912–1913)

Analytical Connectives: *Initially... • This led directly to... • Following this... • Consequently... • As an outcome of this...*
Key Terms: Balkan Powder Keg • Bosnia-Herzegovina • Pan-Slavism • Tsar Nicholas II • Franz Joseph • Greater Serbia • Balkan Wars • pre-emptive war

Question 2: Explain Importance [8 marks • 10 mins]

PART B • IMPORTANCE

Explain the importance of the alliance systems for relations between European great powers before 1914. [8 marks]

Stimulus: The Triple Alliance (1882) | The Triple Entente (1907)

Analytical Connectives: *A decisive factor was... • This was important because... • Furthermore... • As a direct result... • Ultimately, this meant that...*
Key Terms: Dual Alliance • Triple Alliance • Franco-Russian Alliance • Entente Cordiale • Triple Entente • Balance of Power • Encirclement • Domino Effect

LIVING TIMELINE MISSION

Turn to Centrefold • Pages 8–9 →

Turn to Centrefold (Pages 8–9). Complete Milestone 4 (Bismarck Dismissed) and Milestone 7 (Bosnian Crisis) using dual-coding symbols and dates.

Why did a single assassination in Sarajevo ignite thirty-seven days of diplomatic madness and world war?

Core Specification Focus: Archduke Franz Ferdinand inspects Sarajevo (28 June 1914); Young Bosnia and Gavrilo Princip; the Black Hand (Unity or Death) and Apis; the assassination at the Latin Bridge; Kaiser Wilhelm II issues the "Blank Cheque" (5 July); the Austro-Hungarian Ultimatum (23 July); Russian general mobilization (30 July); the Schlieffen Plan; German invasion of neutral Belgium; Britain issues an ultimatum and declares war (4 August 1914).

CHRONOLOGICAL INQUIRY SPINE • CORE CAUSAL NARRATIVE *Construct your causal explanation for each stage incorporating the core trigger terms*

Stage 1 [Text 5.1] 28 June 1914 • What motivated the Black Hand to assassinate Franz Ferdinand in Sarajevo?

• Habsburg Royal Motorcade Route	
• Greater Serbian Conspirators	
• Fatal Revolver Gunfire	

Stage 2 [Text 5.2] 5 July 1914 • How did Germany's "Blank Cheque" escalate the regional crisis?

• Potsdam Imperial Audience	
• Unconditional Military Backing	
• Vienna Emboldened for Retaliation	

Stage 3 [Text 5.3] 23–25 July 1914 • Explain why Austria's Ten-Point Ultimatum made war inevitable.

• 48-Hour Compliance Window	
• Belgrade Police Encroachment	
• Danube Artillery Bombardment	

Stage 4 [Text 5.4] 29–31 July 1914 • In what ways did rigid railway mobilisation schedules trigger the domino effect?

• Tsarist Imperial Decrees	
• Irreversible Rail Deployments	
• Continental Escalation Cascade	

Stage 5 [Text 5.5] 1–4 August 1914 • What forced Great Britain to declare war following the invasion of Belgium?

• 1839 London Treaty Commitment	
• Schlieffen Flanking Offensive	
• Midnight Ultimatum Expiration	

A wrong turn by Franz Ferdinand's chauffeur outside Schiller's Delicatessen brought the Archduke face to face with Gavrilo Princip.

Question 5: Evaluative Statement Essay [12 marks • 15 mins]

SYNOPTIC HISTORICAL VERDICT

"The main cause of the First World War was alliance rivalries." How far do you agree? Explain your answer. [12 marks]

Stimulus: **The Triple Alliance and Triple Entente rivalries** | **The assassination of Archduke Franz Ferdinand** *(You must also use information of your own)*

ANALYTICAL CONNECTIVES:

On one hand, it can be argued that... • A decisive factor supporting this is... • On the other hand... • An alternative argument is that... • In the final analysis...

KEY VOCABULARY BANK:

Alliance Rivalries • Triple Alliance • Triple Entente • Balance of Power • Franz Ferdinand • Blank Cheque • Sarajevo • Schlieffen Plan • Neutrality of Belgium

Task: *Using the vocabulary and connectives above, write your analytical response below:*

LIVING TIMELINE MISSION

Turn to Centrefold • Pages 8–9 →

Turn to Centrefold (Pages 8–9). Complete Milestone 8 (28 June 1914 Sarajevo Assassination) using dual-coding symbols, motorcar, and Latin Bridge.

General Notes

KEY STAGE 3 HISTORY • PUPIL PROGRESS & ASSESSMENT RECORD

PUPIL NAME: _____ **CLASS:** _____ **TARGET KS3 LEVEL:** _____

KEY STAGE 3 HISTORY ASSESSMENT PATHWAYS • LEVEL DESCRIPTORS & CRITERIA

YEAR 9 STANDARDS

EMERGING (1–2)	EMERGING+ (3)	EXPECTED (4–5)	EXPECTED+ (6–7)	GREATER DEPTH (8–9)
Recalls key historical facts; describes basic pre-war crises using guided sentence starters.	Identifies reasons for events; begins to describe causes of alliance friction, naval rivalry, and the July Crisis.	Explains multiple causes & consequences; writes structured causal paragraphs linking M-A-I-N factors with precise evidence.	Analyses causal interaction; evaluates competing historical interpretations and weighs counter-arguments with detailed evidence.	Sustained, nuanced evaluative judgement; synthesises short-term trigger crises against long-term structural imperial forces across 1871–1914.
Focus: *Add dates & key vocabulary.*	***Focus:*** *Explain *why*, not just *what*.*	***Focus:*** *Rank and connect multiple causes.*	***Focus:*** *Sustained historical criteria.*	***Focus:*** *Nuanced synoptic judgements.*

DATE	ENQUIRY • ASSESSMENT FOCUS	KS3 LEVEL / EFFORT	TEACHER COMMENT / SPELLINGS
	Enquiry 1: German Unification, Franco-Prussian & Bismarck Causal Analysis: Why did the German Empire create instability?		
	Enquiry 2: Imperial Rivalry & Moroccan Crises Feature Drill & Consequence of Weltpolitik		
	Enquiry 3: Naval Arms Race & HMS Dreadnought Contrasting Interpretations: Causes of Naval Race		
	Enquiry 4: Alliance Systems & Balkan Powder Keg Narrative Account & Importance of Alliances		
	Enquiry 5: The July Crisis & Sarajevo Outbreak Evaluative Essay: Causes of General European War		
	Teacher-Designated Assessment Task Synoptic End-of-Unit Assessment & Revision Target		

INTERACTIVE DIGITAL QUIZZING HUB • SCAN FOR INSTANT RETRIEVAL PRACTICE

ONLINE RECALL

ENQUIRY 1	ENQUIRY 2	ENQUIRY 3	ENQUIRY 4	ENQUIRY 5
Unification 1871	Morocco & Africa	Dreadnought Race	Alliances & Balkans	Sarajevo 1914
SCAN TO QUIZ	SCAN TO QUIZ	SCAN TO QUIZ	SCAN TO QUIZ	SCAN TO QUIZ
Best Score: [/ 8]	Best Score: [/ 8]	Best Score: [/ 8]	Best Score: [/ 8]	Best Score: [/ 8]

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